

Simplify Life with VirtualBox

VirtualBox allows you to run a number of instances of operating systems on a single machine and seamlessly switch from one OS to another. This article covers how a VirtualBox may be set up on a Windows machine and how it can be used to run other OSs like Windows 8.1 and Chromium. Other uses of VirtualBox are also featured.

VirtualBox has been around for seven years now and it is a good free and open source alternative to proprietary virtualisation platforms like VMware, Microsoft Hyper-V, etc. It provides all the functionality that one expects from a virtualisation platform, and with Oracle as its backbone one need not worry about quality and support.

In this article, we'll tackle some challenges and work out solutions using VirtualBox. However, if you wish to first familiarise yourself with virtualisation concepts and terminology, please refer to the article titled 'Kick-Starting Virtualisation with VirtualBox' published in the March 2013 edition of *Open Source For You*.

Downloading and installing VirtualBox

Follow these steps to download and install VirtualBox on your machine.

Step 1: Navigate to <https://www.virtualbox.org/wiki/Downloads> and download the VirtualBox setup file for Microsoft Windows. The current version, at the time of writing this article, is 4.3.10.

Step 2: Open the location where the setup file has been downloaded and execute the file named *VirtualBox-4.3.10-93012-Win.exe*.

Step 3: Proceed with the installation in the following manner.

Welcome window: Press *Next*.

Custom Setup window: Change installation location if you wish to install VirtualBox in a different location, or else leave everything as is and press *Next*. Uncheck the default settings if you do not wish VirtualBox icons to appear on the desktop or the *Quick Launch* bar. However, keep the *Register file associations* box checked (this will ensure that files associated with VirtualBox open only with VirtualBox). Then press *Next*.

Network Interfaces Warning window: During installation, VirtualBox will reset the network connections. So make sure that any network dependent tasks are



completed before proceeding. Press *Yes* when ready.

Ready to Install window: Press *Install* to begin the installation.



Note: VirtualBox needs to install a few drivers in order to complete the installation. Check *Always trust software from "Oracle Corporation"* and press *Install* when the pop-up is displayed.

Installation Complete window: It should take about 5-6 minutes for the installation to complete. Keep the '*Start Oracle VirtualBox 4.3.10 after installation*' option checked and press *Finish*.

Use-case 1: Create a remote PC and remote storage

Amidst all the chaos around governments breaching our privacy and cloud storage vendors' data centres getting hacked, one thought that often crosses one's mind is: "If only I had my own cloud storage." Look no further. With VirtualBox, a virtual machine (VM) can be created and remote access can be allowed to it. This will eliminate the risk of the host system getting exposed and will provide a sandboxed environment for accessing data remotely. This VM can also be used as a remote PC for working on the go.

Creating the VM

We'll be using Microsoft Windows 8.1 Enterprise. A 90-day evaluation version of Windows 8.1 Enterprise can be downloaded from <http://goo.gl/P7E0q5>.



Note: A Microsoft account is required to download this image file. In case you don't have a Microsoft account, create one at <http://goo.gl/JDNIZZ>.

Once the image file has finished downloading, open VirtualBox and follow the instructions given below to create the VM.